AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 1

What does a team standard actually cover?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 3 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Layer 1 turns the findings from Assess into five shared expectations for using AI well as a team.

Five questions, one focused conversation, one page – shaped with the team, owned by you.

1 One standard, two layers

The **Team Working Standard** has two layers. **Layer 1 – shared expectations:** five minimum agreements that turn the shared conditions into a working document. **Layer 2 – workflows that include AI:** how recurring tasks get done with AI in the process (next lesson).

Organization-level AI guidelines, where they exist, don't tell your team how to work with AI on its everyday tasks. Layer 1 is the team-level version: just enough to change daily behavior. Not a policy handed down – shaped with the team, owned by the manager.

2 Two ways the standard goes wrong

Too big: every scenario, tool, and edge case – comprehensive on paper, ignored in practice. **Too small:** "we use Copilot for drafts and review before sending" – one tool, one review habit; data open, disclosure unstated, direction undefined. What works answers the five questions most teams must resolve first – nothing more.

3 The Five Agreements

Tools – what may be used

Which AI tools are approved, which are not, and how a new tool gets considered. One shared answer instead of individual tool choices.

Data – what may be entered

Clear categories of what stays out, plus one rule that survives time pressure: **when in doubt, leave it out**. Follow the organization's actual data rules – *private* does not mean anything goes.

Review – what must receive human judgment

Which AI-assisted work needs a human look before it is used or shared – internal and client-facing may differ. This is the minimum; workflow detail comes in Layer 2.

Disclosure – when AI involvement must be visible

Not every prompt – only the cases where knowing AI was involved would change how a manager, colleague, or client reads the work. Useful visibility, not surveillance.

Direction and Support – where the team is going, what people need

Where AI should create value, which capabilities must stay strong, what support people need to take part. One or two sentences — not a mission statement or a training plan.

4 Before the session: separate fixed from open

If the organization has mandated a tool, Agreement 1 is pre-answered — name it and move on: **a mandate decides the tool, not the standard**. If guidance is partial or absent, don't treat silence as approval: use what exists, set conservative interim boundaries, and take open questions to whoever owns them. Review, disclosure, and direction and support don't need to wait. The principle: fix what is fixed, set interim boundaries, build what is within your authority, escalate the rest.

Then frame the session: **not a restriction on AI use** — a framework for using it well. The team's input shapes the answers; fixed constraints stay fixed; where something stays stuck or carries real risk, you make the call after the team is heard.

5 One conversation, one page

THE SESSION IN THREE STEPS

1. **Review the Team AI Baseline together** — patterns across the team, not individual responses. Let people react before deciding.
2. **Build the five agreements one by one** — start from any fixed constraint, then ask: *"Within that boundary, what answer will work for this team?"* One or two sentences each.
3. **Read it back and write it down** — check the wording says what was agreed, log what must go up to IT or Legal, circulate the clean draft.

Note: imperfect is fine — a short follow-up can fix anything unclear.

The output is one page: five sections, one or two sentences each. The discussion will be richer than the document — that is right: write down the decisions, not the reasoning. Not a policy — a **working agreement**, revisited with the team quarterly. Step one, not the finish line: Layer 2 adds how recurring tasks run with AI inside them.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Resist the policy instinct — build the standard **with the team**, at team level.
- Keep it to the five agreements — answer them and stop.
- Separate fixed constraints from team decisions before the session — silence is not approval.
- Hold the line: everyone's input shapes the answers; the final call stays with you.
- Leave with something written — one page the team can put to work.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working — this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. **Next: Lesson 3.4 — How to Build the Team Working Standard — Layer 2** — taking the five agreements into the work itself.